

Fishing Log — User Guide

Smith Mountain Lake · A Private Fishing Log for Our Crew

Version 3.0 · Created by John Parrent

Fishing Log is a free web app for logging your Smith Mountain Lake striper trips — what you caught, where, and under what conditions. Over time it builds YOUR playbook: which water temps, baits, moon phases, and spots actually produce. It runs in any web browser on your computer or phone. There is nothing to install.

Web address: <https://fishing-log-fmvre8u5mrqhfsgsfhxroj.streamlit.app>

1. Signing in

Open the web address above and click **Sign in with Google**. You'll use your regular Google account — there is no separate password to remember. Your trips are private to your email address: nobody else in the club can see your data, and you can't see theirs.

First-time heads-up: most people go straight through, but Google MAY show a one-time screen that says "Google hasn't verified this app." If you see it, click **Advanced**, then **Go to Fishing Log**, then **Continue**. Google shows that notice only because our app hasn't gone through their formal (paid) verification process. The app itself is private, and you'll never see the screen again.

If sign-in tells you that you don't have access yet, your email hasn't been added to the approved list — just ask John Parrent (Striper Club Member) to add you.

Want to look around first?

Click **Try the Demo** on the sign-in page. You'll get a read-only tour with 15 sample trips already loaded so you can click through every page. Nothing you do in the demo can break anything.

2. Logging a trip (Log a Session)

This is the page you'll use most, and it works the same on a phone as on a computer. It's in three numbered sections — **1 The trip**, **2 Where you fished**, **3 What you caught** — and **one Save button at the very bottom** that saves all of it together. Work down the page, hit Save once, done. It takes about a minute.

Only two things are actually required: the date and the location. Everything else is optional. Fill in what you know and skip the rest.

1 · The trip

- Date and location (location is pre-filled with Smith Mountain Lake).
- Start and end time — dropdowns in 15-minute steps. Hours fished works itself out.

- Weather and number of anglers (anglers is used for your DWR report).
- **More detail** holds air temp, water temp and notes. Open it if you took readings; ignore it if you didn't.

Primary fishing method used this day

Pick the **one** bait and the **one** style the day was mostly about. This matters for two reasons: every fish you log below starts out set to it, so you rarely have to touch it again; and on a day you catch nothing it's the only record of how you fished. Any other technique you tried can be set on the individual fish further down.

Using something that isn't in the list? Open **Add a bait or style that isn't in the list** and type it. Once you log a fish with it, it stays in your list for good.

2 · Where you fished

- Pick one of two buttons: **Drop pins on a map** or **Describe it in notes**. Nothing opens until you pick, and you can skip both.
- **Describe it in notes** is for when you'd rather just write it down, like "north side of the Hales Ford bridge, 30 ft."
- **Drop pins on a map** works as below, with an optional notes box under the map.
- Click the map to drop your starting pin. Click again to add each spot along your troll.
- The map opens centered on the water you fished **last trip** — handy if you pound the same spots.
- Under the map, enter how many fish you caught at each spot (0 = none). Spots with fish show a fish icon on the map, with an xN badge when you caught several there.
- Use the **Last** button to undo the most recent pin or **Clear** to start over.
- Skipping the map is fine — the trip just won't get a pin.

Tracking your trolling route

This is one of the coolest features. Don't stop at one pin — click the map again at each point along your troll. Later, when you open that trip in Browse & Search, you'll see your whole route drawn out: the pins are numbered in the order you dropped them, a line with arrows shows the direction you trolled, and a fish icon marks every spot where you entered a fish count.

Not trolling? Multiple pins still work great — drop one on each hole you fished that day.

Good to know: the big Map page shows ONE pin per trip, and it uses your FIRST pin. So make your first click the spot that best represents the trip — usually where you started — then add the rest of the route after it.

3 · What you caught

There are two tables here, and you can use either or both on the same trip. Both start with a row already set to **Striper**, since that's what most of us are after.

Fish you measured — one row each

Pick a species, then enter length, depth and weight. Caught another? Click the blank row at the bottom and it becomes a new fish. Check **Kept?** for harvested fish; leave it unchecked for released.

A fish counts here once it has a length or a weight. Depth and Kept are extras. As you add fish, a green line reads your sizes back to you (for example “✓ 2 measured fish added: 24", 31"”) so you know it took. Caught some you didn't measure? Put them in the next section instead. Measure your fish and the Sizes and Personal Bests pages come alive.

Each row also has **Bait** and **Style**, already set to your primary method. Change them on any fish you caught a different way — and the next row you add keeps whatever you picked last, so a run of them is one click, not one per fish.

The small checkbox on the far LEFT of each row is only for deleting rows: check it and a trash can appears at the top of the table. You don't need it for normal entry.

Fish you counted but didn't measure

For the tail end of a good day. Twenty fish in the boat and you measured three of them? Enter the three above, then use this for the other seventeen: how many, and the sizes you saw. Smallest and largest are both optional, so fill in either one or both. Set the bait and style for the group, and tick Kept if they were harvested.

It's recorded honestly as a range — the app never pretends those were seventeen individual measurements. The biggest end of your range still counts for your personal best, because "my biggest was 32 inches" is something you saw, not a guess.

Fished two ways? Use **Add another group** — one group for the spoon fish, another for the downline fish. Each group carries its own bait and style.

Leave **How many** at blank or zero and the group is simply ignored.

Got skunked?

Leave the fish tables empty and press Save. The app asks **Save this as a skunked trip?** so a forgotten catch never turns into a skunk by accident. Tap **Yes, I got skunked**. Skunked trips are real data — they're what makes your success rate mean anything.

Saving

As you enter fish, a running total appears — “23 fish this trip — 1 measured individually, 22 in groups”. Check it matches what's in the boat, then press **Save this trip** at the bottom. It saves everything: the trip, the map and every fish, in one go.

Saving takes a few seconds — you'll see *Saving your trip...* while it works. Then the page changes to show **Trip saved**, exactly what was recorded, and your DWR report card if you logged stripers. Press **Log another trip** to start the next one.

Once a trip is saved the form is gone on purpose, so nobody accidentally saves the same trip twice. To change it, open it under Browse & Search and edit it there.

3. Filing your DWR striper report

Virginia DWR asks striper anglers to report each outing. The app does the paperwork for you: after you save a trip, a report card appears with your numbers already totaled.

- **Step 1 — Open pre-filled DWR report:** opens the official Google Form with your date, hours, anglers, and harvested/released counts and sizes already filled in. Review it and hit Submit.
- **Step 2 — Mark as filed to DWR:** check this box after you submit so the app knows it's done.

Once you check Step 2, that report is a done deal — the card switches to "Filed on (date)" and the buttons go away so nobody can accidentally double-file. If you later edit a filed trip, the app reminds you that the state already has its copy. Checked the box by mistake? There's an **Unmark** button inside the trip's edit form.

The Dashboard shows a reminder listing any trips you haven't filed yet.

4. Reviewing trips (Browse & Search)

- Filter by date range, location, or species at the top of the page.
- Each trip shows as a card — click **Open trip** and it opens on its own page.
- The trip page shows everything: conditions, the fish, your trolling route on a map, and the DWR report status.
- **Back to all trips** at the top and bottom returns you to the list.
- **Edit this trip** opens the same three sections you used to log it, with one **Save changes** at the bottom. **Cancel editing** backs out without saving.
- **Filter trips** at the top is collapsed until you need it — trips are newest first.
- **Delete this session** is at the very bottom, on purpose — it can't be undone.

5. Calendar

- A month grid of your season: **green** days = caught fish, **gray** days = skunked, white = no trip.
- Each trip day shows the fish count and location; the moon phase icon appears in the corner.
- Navigate with Prev / Next, jump to **Today**, or hit **Year ago** to compare against last season.
- Below the grid, every trip that month is listed — click **View** → to read the full detail without leaving the page.

6. Analytics

This is where the log pays off. Pick a year and browse the tabs:

Analytics runs on whatever you've entered — a fish logged without a weight still counts as a fish everywhere; it just won't appear in the size and weight charts. The more detail you log, the more these pages can tell you.

- **Monthly:** trips, fish, and success rate by month.
- **Sizes:** how your fish measure up over the season.
- **Personal Bests:** your longest and heaviest fish, by species, with dates.

- **What's Working:** your most productive water temps, weather, baits, styles, and times — ranked by fish per hour.

Backing up from a phone

The download works fine on a phone, but where it lands matters. On an iPhone it goes to **Files** → **Downloads**; on Android, your **Downloads** folder.

Then move it off the phone. A backup that only exists on your phone does not survive losing your phone, and there is no copy on our side to fall back on. On an iPhone: Files → Downloads → press and hold the file → Move → iCloud Drive. On Android: Files → Downloads → Share → Save to Drive. Emailing it to yourself works on either and is the easiest to find again later.

If the download button seems to do nothing, you are probably in an in-app browser — the one that opens when you tap a link inside Facebook or Messenger. Those block downloads. Open the app in Safari or Chrome instead and it will work.

7. Map

- Every trip's spot on one map, color-coded by how the day went: Skunked (0), Good (1–3), Great (4–6), Blowout (7+).
- Click a pin for the trip's date, conditions, bait, and catch.
- Turn on the **catch hotspots** checkbox for a heat map of everywhere you've actually caught fish.
- Each trip appears as one pin — specifically the FIRST pin you dropped when logging it (your full trolling route lives in the trip's detail under Browse & Search).
- The same date/location/species filters apply, and there's a full-screen toggle.

8. Backup & Export

The **Backup & Export** page downloads a single ZIP with EVERYTHING: your trips, every fish (with kept/released), and your map spots and routes — plus a backup.json file the app can restore from. Grab one every month or so and stash it somewhere safe.

- **Download full backup (ZIP)** — the one button that backs up everything.
- **Restore from backup** — upload a backup ZIP and the app loads those trips back into your account. Trips you already have are skipped automatically.
- Prefer spreadsheets? The individual Sessions and Fish CSVs are still there under "Individual CSVs" — handy for Excel, but the ZIP is the real backup.

9. Using it on your phone

The app works in your phone's browser and is tuned for smaller screens — bigger buttons, a compact calendar, and a simpler layout.

- Tap the teal **Menu** button (top-left) to open the page list; it closes itself after you pick a page. When the menu is open, **Hide menu** tucks it away.

- **Make it feel like a real app:** in Safari or Chrome, tap Share → **Add to Home Screen**. You get a Fishing Log icon that opens full-screen, no address bar.
- The computer is still the best place for map-heavy work like setting trolling routes; the phone is great for logging a trip at the dock and checking your log anywhere.

10. Quick answers

Is my data private?

Trips are tied to your email, and the app only ever shows you your own log — no other member can see it. (As with any shared cloud database, John, as the administrator, can access the database when maintaining the app.)

I got skunked. Do I still log it?

Absolutely — skunked trips are data too, and the DWR wants those reports just as much. Leave the fish tables empty, press Save, and tap Yes, I got skunked.

I made a mistake on a trip.

Browse & Search → Open trip → Edit this trip. Fix it and press Save changes. Cancel editing backs out without changing anything.

Can I lose my data?

It lives in a cloud database, not on your phone. There is no second copy on our side, though, so download a full backup ZIP every month or so — the Restore button puts everything back from it. See section 6 for doing this on a phone.

Something looks broken.

Note what page you were on and what you clicked, then tell John Parrent. The 'build' number at the bottom of the menu helps troubleshooting.

Have an idea to make it better?

Tell John Parrent! The app is homegrown and always improving — member suggestions are where the best features come from.

Tight lines!